

Where Idea-X lacks is that anyone can look at the ideas on the site and use them any way they want. A more rigid system is offered by PLX Systems, “an online market for intellectual property.” At www.pl-x.com, you can buy and sell registered intellectual property. This may sound too commercial, and against the nature of the Internet, but it’s an example of the “expert login” principle we talked about—you give something, you take something.

Idea-X and PL-X are isolated examples; the Overbrain will likely incorporate a vast meme-exchange network. On the Overbrain, memes could sprout all on their own: they could be inferred or detected from documents! They will spread, they will morph, they will be downloaded and uploaded, they will die out—all based on how useful or interesting they are. It happens on today’s Internet, but slowly. Think about the way a good idea hits *your* brain, activating several concepts and eliciting several responses at the speed of thought. And extend that to an Overbrain, with its rich hyperlinks, its agents buzzing around, its analysis of its own knowledge and ideas!

Giving It The Push

There is an important issue we’ve glossed over. There are certain things the Overbrain would not be able to imbibe all on its own; it would need an initial push—notably in the direction of traditional artificial intelligence. It would have to have some of its links structured as relationships; and it would need to have common sense. Here, we can mention that projects such as *Cyc* (Refer *The Lizard Of Oz, Digit*, January 2006) are aiming to build a system that encompasses all of human common sense, for example, that if your father has three sons, you have two brothers. Such a common-sense system could be integrated into the Overbrain.

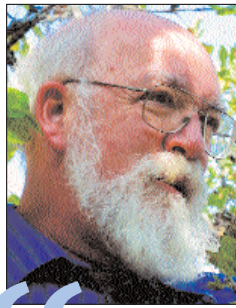
On the point of relationships, the Overbrain should know, taking the example of a cat, that:

1. It is a *member of* the mammal class and of the animal class
2. It *has* feet and a tail
3. It is a pet

And so on. Reciprocally, “tail” should be linked as a *member of* animal bodies; “pet” should *include* cats, dogs, and so forth. Semantic Web technologies, which we mentioned earlier, are ideally suited to the marking up of information on the Web in this way.

Today, we interact with the Internet by way of keywords. This is akin to the age of machine language in programming.

Humans and the Overbrain will interact in natural language, which



If we don’t want to be dictated to, we’ll have to be very careful about controlling our dependence, and the evolution of the Global Brain

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means that the Overbrain will need to have natural language understanding capabilities. We can also think about more sophisticated interfaces, and about downloading stuff directly to our brain. But such a tight integration of man and machine is the subject of another discussion altogether!

Beyond A Repository

At this point, we’re talking about an entity that has all the knowledge humans have, that can think, learn and adapt, that “knows what it knows”, and that can easily communicate with us. What sphere of life would be spared from such an entity? Wherever there’s knowledge, information, or intelligence involved, it would be a two-way flow between humans and the Overbrain. Would there be any need for schools and teachers any more? What would universities and think-tanks become but “Overbrain exchange centres”? Would there be a need for non-fiction books any more?

We learn from blogger Stephen Pratt (<http://stephenpratt.com>) that Heylighen said in 2000: “Whatever problem people have, any kind of question to which they want an answer, it will all become easier because the Web will self-organise and adapt to what people expect of it.” And Heylighen reportedly went on to say that all the technology required to enable an Overbrain is already there—and that “the main stumbling block is the difficulty of convincing the powers behind the Internet to adopt the common protocols that will be needed.”

Being a repository of information is all fine. The Internet already is one. The interesting possibilities arise when the Overbrain begins analysing its knowledge. When it begins forming its own beliefs. When it becomes ... aware?

Whether or not the Overbrain will develop consciousness, we’ll leave to the philosophers. But when the Overbrain has beliefs and opinions of its own, it will take on more *control*. And why not? What sophisticated system in the world today doesn’t depend on computers for its functioning? And when it comes to an Overbrain, who will not hand over control to something that knows much more than what an individual brain can ever know?

Beyond students and learning and books, think of governments, or corporations, and how they might turn to the Overbrain for help in decision making. Would not an overbrain dictate policies? Would it not run *everything*?

A Skynet?

Skynet is the fictional computer network in the *The Terminator* series of movies that turns against mankind. If we’re saying we’ll hand control over to an Overbrain, won’t it take over us? Let’s start with a warning from someone in the know. Daniel Dennett is a professional philosopher, and the author of several mind-body-brain bestsellers. From Pratt’s site, Dennett says, “The global communication network is already capable of complex behaviour that defies the efforts of human experts to comprehend. And what you can’t understand, you can’t control. We’ve already made ourselves so dependent on the network that we cannot afford not to provide it with the energy and maintenance it needs.” Dennett goes on, “If we don’t want to be dictat-